

BLAMO CLOSING

THE TRADE-IN OBJECTION PLAYBOOK



The “I Want More for My Trade-In” Playbook

Ten closes for the trade-in standoff—
plus the owner’s favorite trade close.

The “I Want More for My Trade-In” Playbook

“I want more for my trade-in” is one of the most common objections in automotive sales—and one of the most emotional. The vehicle is theirs, and they feel the number is a judgment of its value. The best approach: acknowledge the customer’s perspective, explain how trade values are determined, and bring the focus back to the overall deal rather than just one number.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Work one close per shift. Say the scripts out loud until they sound like you, adapt the brackets to the real customer, and never read from the page in front of a customer. Use the checklist on each page to grade yourself after every real attempt.

THE HONESTY RULE

Never promise a trade number you can’t deliver. If you say you’ll take it to your manager, take it. Customers compare notes, and one broken promise costs more than one deal.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE

The trade is one number; the deal is the whole picture. Every close in this playbook moves the conversation from a single figure to what it actually costs to upgrade.

7-DAY PRACTICE PLAN

- Day 1: learn the Isolation Close and the Commitment Close.
- Day 2: practice the Big Picture Close and the Reality Close.
- Day 3: run the Market Close and the Team Close.
- Day 4: drill the Difference Close and the Comparison Close.
- Day 5: practice the Fairness Close and the Cost of Waiting Close.
- Day 6: master the Favorite Trade Close—your go-to.
- Day 7: full role-play with real numbers and a stubborn teammate.

The Ten Closes

01 The Isolation Close

GOAL

Isolate the trade value as the only obstacle—or find the real one.

WHEN TO USE IT

Your default when the customer opens with trade value. It agrees first, then isolates.

WHAT TO SAY

“I completely understand—you want every dollar you can get for your trade. Let me ask you this: If we could agree on the trade value, is there anything else that would keep you from taking this vehicle home today?”

WHY IT WORKS

It validates the customer’s position before asking anything—and the answer tells you whether the trade is the real issue or just the loudest one.

CHECKLIST

- Validate first, no “buts.”
- Ask the isolation question exactly.
- Listen for the other objections in the answer.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Run the Isolation Close on your next trade-in conversation. Write down the first objection the customer names after “yes, if we agreed.”

02 The Big Picture Close

GOAL

Shift the conversation from one figure to the overall transaction.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer is locked onto the trade number and the deal is otherwise close.

WHAT TO SAY

“I understand. At the end of the day, is it more important what we allow for your trade, or what it costs you to upgrade to the new vehicle?”

WHY IT WORKS

It reframes the negotiation around the customer’s real interest—what the upgrade costs. Most customers will admit the total matters more.

CHECKLIST

- Ask the question genuinely, not rhetorically.
- Show the total picture on paper.
- Anchor on the upgrade cost, not the trade alone.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Build a one-page total-deal worksheet: trade, price, incentives, total. Practice walking a customer through it on the next deal.

03 The Market Close

GOAL

Be honest about the market—and trade effort for commitment.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer believes you can simply pay more and needs to understand that the market sets the number.

WHAT TO SAY

“If I could pay more for every trade, I absolutely would. The challenge is that the market determines what we can offer. If I go back to my manager one more time and we do everything we can, are you ready to earn our best effort by moving forward today?”

WHY IT WORKS

It is honest about how trade values work, and it makes the manager trip meaningful—you’re asking for commitment before you go fight for them.

CHECKLIST

- Explain the market honestly, with comps if possible.
- Ask for the commitment before going to the manager.
- Come back with a real answer either way.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Prepare one honest market comparison for a vehicle on your lot this week. Know it cold before you need it.

04 The Fairness Close

GOAL

Let the customer see their own request from the other side of the desk.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer's number is far above market and you need a respectful reality check.

WHAT TO SAY

"Can I ask you this—if our positions were reversed, would you expect us to pay more than what the vehicle is actually worth in today's market?"

WHY IT WORKS

It is a fairness question, not a lecture. Most customers will answer honestly—and that answer becomes the foundation of the deal.

CHECKLIST

- Ask it calmly, without challenge in your voice.
- Accept their answer and build from it.
- Move to the Difference Close to find the gap.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Role-play the Fairness question with a teammate until it sounds curious, not challenging.

05 The Difference Close

GOAL

Turn “I want more” into a number you can work with.

WHEN TO USE IT

Any time the customer won’t name a figure. This gets it.

WHAT TO SAY

“How much more were you hoping to get for your trade?”

After they answer: “If I could get you close to that number, would we have a deal today?”

WHY IT WORKS

It converts a vague objection into a specific gap—and a specific commitment. “Close to that number” keeps the goal realistic instead of all-or-nothing.

CHECKLIST

- Ask for the number, then stay quiet.
- Get the commitment before you move.
- If the number is far off, use the Market or Fairness Close.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Ask the Difference Close on your next pushback. Log the number they name and the commitment you got.

06 The Cost of Waiting Close

GOAL

Show what waiting actually costs.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer wants to “wait for a better number” and the vehicle or incentives are time-sensitive—truthfully.

WHAT TO SAY

“I understand wanting more. The only thing I’d hate to see happen is waiting for another \$500 on your trade while missing out on thousands in incentives or the exact vehicle you want.”

WHY IT WORKS

It frames the trade gap against real money on the table. Only use it when the incentives or inventory claims are true.

CHECKLIST

- Verify incentives and availability first.
- Do the math out loud, on paper.
- Let the customer draw the conclusion.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Check the current incentives and inventory on your hot vehicles. Know exactly what “waiting” would cost this week.

07 The Reality Close

GOAL

Force a clear trade-off—more on the trade or a better overall deal.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer is fixated on the trade number and needs to see the whole picture.

WHAT TO SAY

“Would you rather have another \$1,000 for your trade but pay \$2,000 more for the new vehicle, or maximize your overall deal today?”

WHY IT WORKS

Real numbers beat arguments. When the customer sees the \$1,000/\$2,000 trade-off, the right answer becomes obvious.

CHECKLIST

- Use real numbers from the actual deal.
- Present both options neutrally.
- Ask which they prefer—and honor the answer.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Take your next sticky deal to paper: trade \$1,000 vs. deal \$2,000. Present both and let the customer choose.

08 The Team Close

GOAL

Position yourself as the customer's ally inside the dealership.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer trusts you but not the numbers. Bring the manager in as a team, not an enemy.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm on your side. Let's work together to see if we can bridge the gap. If my manager helps us out, can we wrap this up today?"

WHY IT WORKS

It changes the dynamic from you-versus-customer to customer-plus-you versus the gap—and it earns the right to go ask.

CHECKLIST

- Mean it when you say you're on their side.
- Ask the commitment before going to the manager.
- Come back with the best real number.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Pick one deal this week to take to the manager as a team. Ask for the commitment before you leave the desk.

09 The Comparison Close

GOAL

Find out whether you're competing with a real offer or an expectation.

WHEN TO USE IT

When the customer names a number with no source. Get the source.

WHAT TO SAY

"How did you arrive at the value you're looking for? Was it another dealer, an online estimate, or something else?"

WHY IT WORKS

It tells you what you're really up against. A written offer is a real competitor—handle it head-on. A number from memory is an expectation—test it with the Market Close.

CHECKLIST

- Ask for the source, not just the number.
- If it's a real offer, ask to see it.
- If it's an expectation, walk through the market.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Ask every trade-in customer where their number came from this week. Sort the real offers from the expectations.

10 The Commitment Close

GOAL

Get a realistic commitment before you go ask for more.

WHEN TO USE IT

When you're about to take the request to the manager and need to know what "yes" looks like.

WHAT TO SAY

"If I can get my manager to improve your trade value—even if it's not all the way to your number—are you ready to take your new vehicle home today?"

WHY IT WORKS

It sets expectations honestly—improvement, not a miracle—and it guarantees your manager trip means something.

CHECKLIST

- Be clear that it may not reach their number.
- Get the "yes" before you leave the desk.
- Deliver on whatever you bring back.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE TODAY

Practice the Commitment Close until "even if it's not all the way to your number" sounds calm and honest—then use it before every manager trip.

The Favorite Trade Close

This is the close the owner reaches for when the trade-in number gets sticky. It validates, sets expectations, gains commitment, and keeps the focus on the whole deal—all in one question.

WHAT TO SAY

“Mr./Mrs. Customer, I completely understand wanting more for your trade—I would too. Let me ask you one question: If my manager and I do everything we reasonably can to maximize your trade value, and the numbers make sense overall, are you ready to take your new vehicle home today?”

WHY IT WORKS

- It validates the customer’s concern. You agree with them before asking anything—they stay open, not defensive.
- It sets realistic expectations. “Everything we reasonably can” and “the numbers make sense overall”—no miracles promised.
- It gains a commitment before asking the manager for additional consideration. You never go to the desk without knowing what a yes looks like.
- It keeps the conversation focused on reaching an agreement, not arguing over a single number.

WHEN TO USE IT

Any time the customer pushes back on trade value and you need a respectful way to move forward. It is your anchor close—practice it until it is automatic.

HOW TO DELIVER

Slow, calm, and sincere. Say the customer’s name. Do not rush the last question—that’s the one you need answered.

How to Use Them

The best approach is to acknowledge the customer's perspective, explain how trade values are determined, and then bring the focus back to the overall deal rather than just one number.

REAL OFFER OR EXPECTATION?

- The customer has a real offer in writing—ask to see it and take it seriously. Compare apples to apples: same miles, condition, and equipment.
- The number came from memory or a neighbor—walk through market value honestly and let the market do the talking.
- The customer keeps circling back to the trade while the new-vehicle numbers sit untouched—use the Big Picture Close.
- The customer is ready to buy but wants the win—use the Favorite Trade Close and give them the win the right way.

THE GROUND RULES

Never insult the customer's vehicle. It is theirs, and they will hear every word as an attack.

Keep numbers on paper, not in the air. Write the trade, the price, the incentives, and the total—the whole picture beats any single number.

Quick Reference

1. Isolation — if we agree on the trade, is anything else holding you back?
2. Big Picture — trade value or total upgrade cost?
3. Market — the market sets the number; best effort for a yes.
4. Fairness — would you pay more than it's worth?
5. Difference — how much more? Close to that = deal today?
6. Cost of Waiting — \$500 now vs. thousands later.
7. Reality — \$1,000 more on trade or \$2,000 better deal?
8. Team — let's bridge the gap together.
9. Comparison — where did that number come from?
10. Commitment — improved trade, not all the way—ready today?

The Favorite — everything reasonable + numbers make sense = home today?

WHERE TO GO NEXT

Explore The Sales Rep Starter Kit for the five core closes, The 10 Steps of the Sale for the in-store floor process, The 10 Steps to the Internet Sale for online leads, and The Five Closes in Action for realistic dialogue. Blamo Closing training is practical, honest, and built for the work in front of you.